

Microsoft 365 Copilot Analytics

Data Strategy

Entra ID vs. Org Data Upload — What to connect, why, and how to decide

Document Property	Value
Section	Strategy
Audience	Solution Architect, IT Admin, CIO
Version	4.2
Last validated	2 October 2026

How This Document Fits

This is a **Strategy** guide. Read this to decide your data approach. Then hand off to IT with the Data Onboarding Guide for step-by-step implementation.

1. Why Upload Org Data? (Entra ID vs. Org Data Upload)

A common question: “We already have Department, Manager, and Organisation in Entra ID — why do we need to upload a CSV?”

Entra ID provides a baseline, but org data uploads unlock significantly more analytics capability:

Capability	Entra ID Only	With Org Data Upload
Department filter on dashboard	Yes (Entra ID “Department” attribute)	Yes (from CSV — can use different/cleaner values)
Job Function / Job Discipline filter	No	Yes (via <code>FunctionType</code> / <code>Microsoft_JobDiscipline</code>)
Location attribute (advanced analysis)	No	Yes (via <code>Location</code> attribute). Not a documented Copilot Dashboard filter

Level / Seniority attribute (advanced analysis)	No	Yes (via <code>LevelDesignation</code>). Not a documented Copilot Dashboard filter
Custom attributes (Cost Centre, Agency, BU, Region)	No	Yes (up to 105 attributes in total, including the five required ones)
Multi-agency / multi-BU partitioning	Yes — if each agency has a distinct email domain, use the system-generated <code>Domain</code> attribute (no CSV needed)	Yes — use a custom <code>Agency</code> attribute for maximum flexibility (works even when agencies share one domain)
Before/after cohort segmentation in Power BI	No segmentation	Yes (segment by any uploaded attribute)
Manager hierarchy accuracy	Depends on Entra ID completeness	Can supplement/override with CSV <code>ManagerId</code>
Data freshness control	Updated by directory team (often delayed)	Updated by Insights Admin on a defined cadence

TIP: When Entra ID Alone Is Sufficient

If you **only** need the Copilot Dashboard with tenant-level views and Department filtering — and the Entra ID Department attribute is accurate and consistently populated — you can skip the org data upload. However, if you need **any** of the following, org data upload is required: a Job Function filter, custom attributes (Cost Centre, Agency), or before/after cohort analysis in Power BI. (Location and Level are Viva Insights attributes for advanced analysis; Microsoft documents Scope, Organization, Job function and License type as the Copilot Dashboard filters.)

2. What Breaks with an Incomplete Entra ID Hierarchy?

If the Entra ID `Manager` attribute is missing or inconsistent for many users:

Feature	Impact
Auto CxO Identification	Fewer leaders are auto-identified. Users without a clear reporting line are excluded from the “top 3 levels” calculation.
Manager Settings (team-level data)	Managers without a populated <code>Manager</code> attribute or without enough direct reports won't see team-level data.
Filter by manager hierarchy (Publish Reports)	Published reports with “Filter by manager hierarchy” will show incomplete data.
Advanced Analytics cohort segmentation	Manager-based grouping will be inaccurate.

Recommendation: If more than 20% of users lack a Manager attribute, prioritise fixing directory data or supplement with an org data CSV upload that includes correct `ManagerId` values.

3. Source Precedence Is Surface- and Attribute-Specific

An upload changes the source for the attributes supplied to the apps you select; it does **not** universally or permanently replace Microsoft Entra ID across Microsoft 365. (Microsoft’s Copilot Dashboard article says an upload permanently changes the dashboard data source from Entra ID to the data file; the parallel-ingestion article describes sourcing ManagerId and Organization from Entra alongside uploaded data.)

Surface / attribute	Controlling behaviour	Operational rule
Microsoft 365 User Profile	Microsoft Entra is the default source. Microsoft 365 Organizational Data Service (formerly Organizational Data in Microsoft 365) can be prioritised; when Entra is missing or incomplete, uploaded data can fill gaps.	Keep Profile precedence at Entra unless there is an approved reason to override it.
Copilot Dashboard and Viva Insights	Uploaded data shared with these apps supplies the mapped dashboard and analysis attributes. If both Viva and Microsoft 365 uploads exist, Microsoft documents a merge with the more recent upload taking priority.	Document the owner and source for every supplied attribute; verify values in Dashboard filters and Viva data quality after each change.
Viva ManagerId and Organization	Parallel ingestion can make Entra the default for either attribute, even when the upload also contains it. Other uploaded fields continue to come from CSV or connectors.	Use Configure Entra connection when the directory owns these two attributes; allow about 24 hours for the change.
Uploaded optional and custom attributes	They remain upload/connector sourced unless an app has its own documented precedence rule.	Do not assume an Entra fallback. Keep the source current and test each consuming app.

Sources: Microsoft 365 Organizational Data Service — Data precedence (Microsoft Learn, updated 1 September 2026); Manage settings for the Microsoft Copilot Dashboard, Agent Dashboard, and Viva Insights web app (13 August 2026); and Use Microsoft Entra plus .csv files for parallel data uploads (Last updated 7 July 2026).

Supported correction and rollback paths

- **Update:** Upload only affected users and all attributes you intend to change. A blank value preserves the existing value because new uploads merge with previous data.
- **Delete a value:** Use the documented type-specific marker: two single quotes (`' '`) in CSV for strings (three in Excel), `-1` for integers, a nonexistent in-tenant address for email values, or `01-01-0001` for dates.
- **Correct history:** Use **Historical import** with a CSV and a **File valid as of** date. Microsoft documents historical updates for Viva Insights data only.
- **Return `ManagerId` / `Organization` to Entra:** Enable those attributes under **Configure Entra connection**, then delete uploaded optional attributes you no longer need.
- **Migration failure:** Stop further imports and open a Microsoft support request. Microsoft documents temporary rollback only for critical migration issues in special cases.

Do Not Use a Dummy-Row Rollback

Do not use a one-row “Replace All” file as a general removal or rollback technique. It can leave an artificial hierarchy and break filters, partitions, or reports. Use the supported update/delete markers, parallel Entra restoration, or Microsoft Support instead. Microsoft’s FAQ for admin center uploads separately describes a one-user Replace All upload (with dummy values for `PersonId`, `ManagerId` and `Organization`) as the first step to completely remove all previously uploaded data, followed by deleting the partitions and reports that reference the additional attributes. That is a deliberate full wipe, not a rollback.

Source: Import and manage your organizational data with a .csv file — Update or make other changes (Microsoft Learn, updated 27 August 2026), including retroactive updates; migration rollback is documented in Upload and maintain data through the Microsoft 365 admin center (13 August 2026).

4. Choose Your Upload Method

Start with “What HRIS do you use?” — not “how do I upload a CSV.”

Method	Who Manages	Status	Best For
SAP SuccessFactors Connector	Global Admin + SAP SF Admin	GA	Organisations using SAP SuccessFactors. No CSV needed. Auto-sync weekly/monthly.
Workday Connector	Global Admin + Workday Admin	Supported, up to 100,000 users	Workday SOAP integration. For larger datasets or where SOAP is unsuitable, use Workday RaaS through Azure Blob or API import.
Azure Blob Storage	Global Admin + Data Engineer	Public Preview; Worldwide only	Automated CSV drop. Unavailable in GCC; confirm tenant rollout before production use.
API-Based Import	Global Admin + Developer	Public Preview; Worldwide only	Programmatic import using CSV payloads. Unavailable in GCC; confirm tenant rollout before production use.
CSV Upload — M365 Admin Center	Org Data Source Administrator	GA	Universal fallback. Lowest technical barrier. Works with any HRIS (export to CSV).
CSV Upload — Viva Insights web app	Insights Administrator	Official sources conflict; tenant-specific	Do not infer availability from a date. Follow Message Center and the actual tenant UI; use only when both explicitly show add/edit upload is supported.

Sources: Import organizational data from Workday (Microsoft Learn, updated 27 August 2026); Import organizational data using API-based import (preview) (27 August 2026); and Supported Microsoft 365 environments for Viva Insights features (30 September 2026).

NOTE: Decision Logic

- **Use SAP SuccessFactors or Workday** if your org runs either HRIS — eliminates manual CSV entirely
- **Consider Azure Blob Storage** for automated CSV drops from a data warehouse, subject to public-preview, cloud, and tenant availability
- **Consider API-based import** for programmatic integration or a custom HRIS, subject to public-preview, cloud, and tenant availability
- **Use CSV upload** for everything else — universal compatibility

TIP: Bypass On-Premises AD

If your HRIS data flows through **SAP SuccessFactors → middleware → on-premises AD → Entra ID**, be aware that Viva Insights only picks up 3 attributes from Entra (PersonId, ManagerId, Organization). Custom fields in Entra `extensionAttributes` are **not synced**.

Solution: Use the HRIS connector to send data directly to M365 — bypassing AD entirely for analytics purposes.

5. Data Planning Worksheet

Complete this before any upload. Share answers with your IT team when you hand off to the Data Onboarding Guide.

#	Question	Your Answer
1	Which HRIS does your organisation use? (SAP SF, Workday, Oracle, Custom, None)	
2	Can your HRIS export a CSV with employee email, manager email, and department?	
3	Which dashboard filters do you need beyond Department? (Job Function, Location, Level, Cost Centre, Agency, Region)	
4	Do you need custom attributes for segmentation in Power BI reports? (e.g., Copilot Pilot Group, Hire Date, BU)	
5	Who will own the monthly data refresh? (HR, IT, Data Engineering)	
6	What does the latest Message Center migration notice say, and which add/edit controls are visible in the tenant UI?	
7	Do multiple agencies share a single email domain? (If yes, you'll need a custom Agency attribute for partitioning)	
8	Do you need to share org data with apps beyond Viva Insights? (M365 Profile, People Skills)	

6. Determine the Current Tenant State

Official Microsoft Sources Conflict

Manage settings for the Microsoft Copilot Dashboard, Agent Dashboard, Consumption Dashboard, and Viva Insights web app (13 August 2026) still calls Viva web-app upload the recommended path for Viva Insights customers. Use Microsoft Entra plus .csv files for parallel data uploads (Last updated 7 July 2026) says adding and editing uploads is no longer supported there. Upload and maintain data through the Microsoft 365 admin center (13 August 2026) says migration occurs in tenant-specific waves announced in Message Center.

Safest rule: Message Center and the actual tenant UI control the procedure. A calendar date or missing tile alone does not prove which path is supported.

Current-state gate

1. Read the latest tenant-specific Message Center post for organizational-data migration.
2. Open `admin.microsoft.com` → **Setup** → **Migration and imports** and record whether **Microsoft 365 Organizational Data Service** and its add/edit controls are available (the article “Use your organizational data in Microsoft 365 and Microsoft Viva” describes the same tool under Setup → Migration resources → Explore migration & import tools).
3. Open the Viva Insights web app and record whether organizational-data add/edit, delete, and Replace All controls are present. Do not assume all four move together.
4. Review existing connections so a second source is not introduced unintentionally.
5. If Message Center and the live UI agree, follow that path in the Data Onboarding Guide.
6. If they conflict, or neither surface offers a supported add/edit path, **stop**. Capture the Message Center post ID/date, screenshots, roles, tenant cloud, and existing connection status; then escalate through Microsoft Support or the account team before uploading.

7. What to Read Next

Ready to...	Read this
Upload data (step-by-step)	Data Onboarding Guide (Setup layer)
See the full attribute mapping table	Attribute Reference (Reference layer)
Troubleshoot a failed upload	Troubleshooting Guide (Reference layer)
Understand multi-agency data isolation	Multi-Agency Decision Guide (Decide)

Disclaimer

This guide is provided as a procedural reference. Always refer to Microsoft 365 Organizational Data Service on Microsoft Learn for the most up-to-date information.